



BUDDHA UND

THE VIOLENCE IN KOLKATA IS THE LATEST SETBACK TO CHIEF MINISTER BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARJEE

■ By Abhijit Dasgupta in Kolkata

Why don't you leave us alone? / Why don't you set us free? / Beware all, you powers that be / For all the land a man really needs / Is only six foot by three. One man's shoulder / Another man's gun / The trigger is pulled by a third / The whole mess that we've got into now / Is really quite absurd.

Lyrics to Spirit of Nandigram penned by Kolkata-based singer/activist Usha Uthup

Nandigram has become a metaphor for many things: injustice, mob rule, misuse of state power, forcible occupation of land and goon squads waving CPI(M) flags being given a free rein to destroy at will. After the November 21 violence in Kolkata, it became a metaphor for a larger issue—the death of a dream and the fall from

grace of one of Indian communism's most powerful and popular stars, West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee. For a city used to bandhs and blockades, Black Wednesday—which saw widespread violence and arson—was a sober reminder that Buddhadeb's hold on power was slipping alarmingly, reinforced by the fact that the helpless chief minister had to call in the army to handle a situation which could have been prevented. For Buddhadeb, it has been a terrible year—the shame of Nandigram, his public defence of the CPI(M) goons, his embarrassment over the Rizwanur case, and now, violence in the state capital. The Buddhadeb Bubble may finally have burst.

His government's inept handling of Singur, Nandigram and the Rizwanur

cases apart from the personal loss of face for the chief minister with mega investor Reliance pulling out of West Bengal with its proposed retail chain, the discomfiture of his party comrades and attacks from major political parties, including the UPA, can only suggest that Buddhadeb is under siege. His image as a liberal socialist, a communist who welcomes capitalists, the darling of the intellectuals and the middle classes and the saviour of the minorities is as bedraggled as the haggard look he wears these days. As author Sunil Gangopadhyay remarks, "I am apprehensive about the future. The city's image as a secular place will take a serious beating. Calling in the army was shameful. The last time we did it was 15 years ago, over Babri Masjid."

This is also alarmingly enough for